wonderful gunner…said to me, “If you drink a beaker of wine, it will relieve the exhaustion.” Since I was young and my nature was inclined to do these things, I ordered Mahmud the water-carrier to go to Hakim Ali’s house and bring some alcoholic syrup. The physician sent a phial and a half of yellow-coloured, sweet-tasting wine in a small bottle. I drank it and liked the feeling I got.’ Salim would come to depend on the feeling of invincibility that alcohol and opium gave him in the face of a father who needed nothing other than his own indomitable willpower to meet the various challenges he faced.

Salim may have been the most prominent Mughal at the time to develop a dependence on alcohol but he was by no means an exception. Alcohol, primarily wine, was a part of Mughal life though the pattern of consumption had changed since Babur’s time. Babur had written frankly of drinking parties with his men, evenings that began with poetry and ended in drunken mishaps. But these gatherings were occasional, punctuating a busy, nomadic lifestyle. Now, as Mughal life became more settled, alcohol became a more private pastime, often indulged to excess, known to cause decrepitude and even death. Opium consumption, on the other hand, seemed to provoke no stigma and appeared to be widely used, even outside courtly circles as the poorer folk used it to ease the drudgery of their working day. Alfonso de Albuquerque had already come across the plant in 1513 and, ever the practical merchant, wrote to the Portuguese king to urge him to cover the fields of Portugal with the plant. Indeed, poppy, indigo, and sugar were listed by Abu’l Fazl in 1590 as the three products of the highest value in the land.

Mirza Murad, meanwhile, was married to a daughter of Mirza Aziz Koka in 1587, thereby securing for himself the support of one of the most powerful men in the empire. The wedding was celebrated with éclat in the house of Hamida Banu, and one can imagine the immense satisfaction of Jiji Anaga, as her granddaughter became one of the princesses of the empire. The son of a concubine, Murad was described as a quiet and serious young scholar by the Jesuits. ‘His complexion was dark,’ wrote Salim later in his memoir about Murad, ‘and he was tall in stature, inclining to be portly. Gravity was apparent in his manner, and bravery and manliness were evident from his conduct.’ Mirza Daniyal, on the other hand, was described as ‘a young man of fine stature’, by Salim. ‘He was very fond of elephants and horses… He was fond of Indian singing.’ As each prince married the